

Aaron — The Improvement Brief

A twenty-minute listen. Put it on, close your eyes, and let it play.

Hello Aaron. This is your improvement brief. Everything in here comes from your own recordings — more than a hundred takes, measured note by note and compared against fifty professional reference vocals. Nothing in here is opinion, and nothing in here is a guess. So settle in, have your rest, and let me walk you through where you are, what actually needs work, and exactly what to do about it. There is nothing to write down. The daily programme at the centre of this talk is already in your repository, and you can read it any time. Right now, your only job is to listen.

Let's start with some truth that should let your shoulders drop.

Part one. Where you actually are.

You are a good singer. Not "good for karaoke". Measurably good. When you land on a note, you land an average of twenty to twenty-five cents from dead centre. A cent is one hundredth of a semitone, so that is a quarter of a semitone at most — and the Farnham and Three Doors Down masters land in exactly that window. Your landing accuracy has measured at that level since two thousand nineteen. That is not something you need to fix. That is something you own.

And you have proof that it holds up under the worst conditions. At Brighton, the backing was so loud you could not hear yourself at all — and your Kung Fu Fighting take measured nine point three on the capture-fair scale. On that scale, ten is what a typical professional measures. Singing blind, in a loud room, you were within touching distance of a working pro. Hold onto that, because everything else I'm about to say sits on top of it.

Your range is real too. From a low A two up to an E five in falsetto — about two and a half octaves — with a money zone between B three and B four where your voice sounds genuinely world class. Bright, forward, built for rock and funk and soul. That is the instrument. It works.

So what's left? Three things, really. The way you start notes. The way you hold notes. And the way you finish phrases. That's the whole list. Let me take them one at a time, slowly.

Part two. The approach, not the landing.

Here is the single most valuable thing in this entire brief. Your pitch is not the problem. Your approach to the pitch is.

Only about one entry in four — twenty-four percent — starts cleanly on the centre of the note. The professionals in the reference pack median around thirty-three percent, and Farnham on your own songs runs anywhere from thirty-eight to fifty-seven percent clean. Out of fifty professional references, forty-two of them start their notes more cleanly than your typical take. That is your biggest measured gap, and it is also your biggest opportunity, because your landings are already

professional. You are a sniper who takes the scenic route to the target.

What happens instead of a clean start? Nearly half the time, you slide up into the note from below — from almost a full semitone below. And about three in ten entries, you come in slightly over the top and settle down onto it. A listener's ear hears all of that as loose pitch, even though the note you finally sit on is dead centre. The engine scores where you land. The room hears how you got there.

Now, here's the part I want you to really hear, because it should change how you feel about this. Scooping is not a flaw. When Farnham scoops, he scoops from nearly the same depth you do. The difference is that he does it three times less often — and every single one is a choice. His slide is seasoning. Yours is habit. The goal is not to delete the scoop. The goal is to make the clean entry your default, and then put the scoop back exactly where you want it. That is the difference between style and accident, and it is completely learnable.

The fix has a name you already know: see it, land it, stay on it. Hear the note in your head before you make a sound. If the pitch exists in your mind first, the voice has nowhere to search, and scooping is what a voice does when it is searching. There's a five-minute block in your daily programme built entirely around this, and I'll walk you through it in a few minutes.

Part three. You live on your passaggio.

Here is something nobody had said out loud until recently. The note you sing more than any other note is E four. Your working range on stage runs from about A three to F sharp four. And your gear change — your passaggio — sits right around D four to E four.

Put those three facts together. The place where your voice changes gear is the place you spend most of every night. You live on your passaggio. That is why full nights feel taxing in a way that doesn't quite make sense from the outside. It is not weakness and it is not age. It is geography.

And it means passaggio work is not some advanced extra for you. It is basic maintenance on the most-used part of your instrument, the same way a runner looks after their knees. The good news is that the answer is already in your technique. When the engine measured Farnham's original Pressure Down vocal — your signature song — it found he sings roughly three quarters of it in a light production. Not heavy chest. Light. The man who owns that song treats the exact notes you struggle to sustain as lifted speech, not as a shout. Your lighter upper setup isn't a compromise while you get stronger. It is the correct professional answer, confirmed by the master's own voice.

So when the chorus sits on C sharp four and D four and E four, think mix. Think lifted speech. Let the microphone do the loudness. Every time you muscle chest weight up into that zone, you are paying a tax the song never asked you to pay.

Part four. The honest breath story.

Now, breath. About half of your phrase endings sag — the pitch droops in the last moment before the release. Farnham's own recordings sag on fewer than a third of theirs. So there is a real gap here. But let me tell you what it is not, because you've been sold the wrong story about your own breathing.

Your median phrase is under three seconds long. Nobody — nobody — runs out of air in under three seconds. This is not a lung capacity problem, and long slow breathing exercises aimed at capacity are aimed at the wrong target. What the measurements actually show is that you let go of the support before the phrase is finished. The ribs relax, the pressure drops, and the last word pays for it. The air was there. You released the floor under it.

There's one more honest layer. Some of what gets flagged as sagging is just rock and roll — deliberate fall-offs that the original artists also make. When you sing *Livin' on a Prayer* or *Let's Stay Together*, the falling endings are the song, not you. But on *You Sexy Thing* and *Bye Bye Love*, you fall off notes far more than the records do — those two genuinely are your weakest breath songs, and it is no accident they've been parked out of the competition ladder.

The fix is beautifully simple, and it is silent, so you can do it on a rest day, sick, or right after a gig. It is the Farinelli breath. In for four counts, suspend for four, out for four. And the entire exercise lives inside that suspension — but hear this clearly, because it is the classic mistake: the hold is your ribs staying wide. It is not your throat closing. Here's the test. At the end of a suspension, start a quiet hum straight out of it. If there's a little click or catch or push, you held it at the glottis. Reset, and hold it at the ribs instead.

And on stage, the whole of breath support compresses into three words: last word loud. Carry the intensity all the way to the final syllable instead of letting it trail. Ribs wide until the note has actually ended. That's the sag fixed, in one instruction.

Part five. Held notes that wander.

The third thing is what happens inside your long notes. Right now, a held note of yours drifts by about forty cents while you hold it — it lands, sits for a moment, and then wanders. Farnham's held notes move about fifteen. This is the number listeners feel most, even when they can't name it.

Two drills attack it directly. First, straight tone against a drone. Play any steady reference pitch, sing against it, dead straight, no vibrato, no swell, for eight to ten seconds. Drift is nearly impossible to hear on your own and instantly obvious against a drone — that's the whole trick. Second, *messa di voce*: on one breath, soft, swell to full, back to soft, without the pitch moving a hair. And the rule that governs both: still first, shape second. If the straight tone isn't solid today, don't add the swell today. Under load, your measured habit is to reach for power — the swell has to be earned.

Here's the encouraging part: this is already working. Between your first live *Kung Fu Fighting* take and Brighton one night later, your held-note drift dropped from about forty-two cents to thirty-one.

One night. The professional median is around twenty-four. You are most of the way there.

Part six. The twenty minutes a day.

Now let me walk you through the daily programme, calmly, so that when you do it, it feels familiar. It is twenty minutes, five or six days a week — not seven. The rest day is not laziness; it is when the adaptation actually lands.

It opens with three minutes of semi-occluded work — the straw in the water jar, gentle sirens, then lip trill or straw glides across your comfortable range. This is block zero and it is never skipped, ever. It wakes the folds at a fraction of the collision force, so it prepares the instrument without spending it. It is the cheapest minute in the programme and everything else works better after it.

Then three minutes of the Farinelli breath we just talked about — silent rib work, plus one long steady hiss, aiming over time for twenty-five even seconds.

Then the heart of it: five minutes of onset planting, the biggest block because it is the biggest gap. First, sing one comfortable pitch three ways — breathy, with air before tone; hard, with a little click; and balanced, air and tone arriving together. You cannot fix an onset you cannot feel, and this builds the feel. Then silent-target planting: play a note, stop it, hear it in your head, breathe, and land it — no slide, straight onto the centre, hold two seconds, ten different pitches. And finally, deliberate contrast: take a phrase you know and scoop it on purpose, exaggerated, then sing it clean, and alternate. Contrast is how ears learn, and your scoops are currently invisible to you because they are your normal.

Then four minutes of sustain work — the drone and the messa di voce. Then three minutes of passaggio maintenance: straw glides through the gear change around C sharp four to F four, some ng slides to visit the top of the range cheaply, and descending five-note runs from above the passaggio on a light vowel, bringing the head voice down and blending it.

And the last two minutes: apply it to one phrase of one song. Not the whole song — one phrase, carrying today's focus into real music. Then stretch one phrase length: sing a long line on a single breath, add a beat when it's comfortable. Your median phrase is two point seven seconds; You're the Voice lives at five and a half. That gap closes one beat at a time.

If you're tired, or it's the day after a gig, there's a recovery version: just the straw and the silent breathing. Six minutes, costs the folds almost nothing, keeps the streak alive. And every fourth week, halve everything — you already think in loading and deload weeks for your rib training, and the voice adapts exactly the same way. The easy week is where the gains land.

Part seven. The campaign.

Now, the reason all of this matters this particular spring: December. The competition ladder is already mapped. Warm-up nights on the seventh and fourteenth of October. Heats through late

October and early November. Quarter finals in late November. The semi-final on December second — historically your wall. And the grand final on December ninth. A different song every round, judged every round.

Your ladder is chosen and it is measured. Kung Fu Fighting takes the heat — it survived Brighton with a nine point three when you couldn't hear yourself, and its groove delivery is your wheelhouse. Pressure Down takes the quarter final — your signature, drilled nine times over. And the semi-final showpiece gets decided by the data over the next two months: Reasons, which climbed sharply in a single week of work, against You're the Voice, the Aussie anthem with the highest ceiling. One take of each, every week, and by October the trend lines make the decision for you. No guessing. Oh What a Night and One stand by as backups.

But here is what the history actually says, and I want you to take this in while you're relaxed, because it is the most important sentence in the campaign. What has beaten you in past years is not skill. It is the pressure response. Under nerves, you push — the loud gear comes out early, the slides get deeper, the support gets abandoned for volume. The measurements caught it, and they also caught the antidote working: at Brighton, with no monitoring at all, you sang your best measured live take by staying inside yourself. So the one cue that goes on stage with you — and only one, because under adrenaline one cue survives and three don't — is this: keep one gear in reserve. The microphone does the loudness. Let the chorus pull the power out of you; never push it out.

And one more thing the numbers proved: there is no song two in a competition. Across a normal night, your accuracy climbs song by song — your third song is one to three points better than your first. In a heat, you get one song, cold. So you arrive in song-three condition: the full warm-up at home, singing in the car on the way, quiet singing along at the venue. That routine is worth more than any drill in this brief. And your Friday karaoke nights now have a job: they are pressure inoculation. The score does not matter on Fridays. Executing "one gear in reserve" with adrenaline in your blood — that is the entire assignment.

Part eight. The rules that override everything.

A few hard rules, and then I'll let you rest properly.

Never train through hoarseness. Mild irritation that clears overnight is just fatigue. Hoarseness still there after a full rest day is a stop sign. Pain is always a stop — singing should feel free, always. If hoarseness lasts a week, or you lose top notes and they don't come back, that is a doctor, ideally one who scopes, not a wait-and-see. On rest days, speak quietly but never whisper — whispering is harder on the folds than soft speech. You cannot train two systems to failure at once, so in the weeks you are pushing the rib loading hard, do not also push the voice to symptoms. And inside the last nine weeks before the competition, fresh beats drilled — an easy week costs you nothing, but arriving tired costs you everything.

Part nine. How you'll know it's working.

Last thing. Do not judge this programme by feel. Feel lies, especially to singers. Once a month, record one take of Pressure Down or Reasons in the same conditions, and look at just four numbers. Clean entries — aiming from twenty-four percent up past thirty-three, which is the professional middle of the pack. Sagging endings — from about half down under thirty-five percent. Drift inside held notes — from forty cents down under twenty-five. And median phrase length — from under three seconds up past four. Those are raw measurements, always comparable, no caveats.

And don't expect the overall score to leap even when all four improve — the things you're fixing are exactly the things the score weights lightly. That is a known limitation of the number, not a failure of the work. The point of this programme was never to move a score. It is to sound better to a room full of people on a Friday night, and to a panel of judges on the second of December. The blind listening test already proved your ear hears these improvements even when the score doesn't.

So here's the whole brief in four sentences. Your landings are professional — now clean up the approach: see it, land it, stay on it. Live lighter on the gear change you stand on all night. Keep the ribs wide to the last word, and keep held notes still before you shape them. And when the lights are on, one gear in reserve — the microphone does the loudness.

Twenty minutes a day, five days a week, one recorded take a month. Everything else is patience. You are closer than you think, Aaron — the instrument is already there, and now it's just aim. Enjoy the rest. You've earned it.